

Scorched Earth

Widow's Bight, 1940s

His mother had named him Ekon because she wanted a word in her son's mouth that the world would have to reckon with before it got around to insulting him, and Ekon Freeman had spent forty-one years finding out exactly how little a name buys a man on its own. Strong was a fact about him now, verified the hard way, in places whose names he did not put in letters home. Freeman had been a fact about his family for longer than the town north of the point had ever been willing to admit — his mother's people free by law a full generation before the Ophion went down and made three white families rich off the wreckage, free by law before Massachusetts had finished arguing itself into abolishing the practice at all, and none of that had stopped the town clerk, twenty years back, from writing *transients* in a public record next to his mother's and his brother's names, as though a family with a longer claim on that coastline than the Ophion's own owners could be filed away as people who simply hadn't gotten around to belonging anywhere yet.

He had gone to war and come back exactly as capable as the Army had spent three years teaching him to be, and he intended, for once in his family's dealings with this town, to use every bit of that competence on something that would actually hold still and be solved. He had learned, overseas, the specific discipline of a man who plans an operation down to its contingencies and then executes it without asking the ground's permission a second time. He meant to bring that discipline home and spend it, at last, on his own family's account rather than someone else's war.

[MATCHES: 24]

The lawyer's office smelled like a man who did not open his windows on principle. Adrian Voss had represented Ekon's mother in her last years, badly and half-heartedly, and had not destroyed a single document she'd left in his keeping only because destroying documents was a specific kind of trouble a careful man avoided, not because he had ever once intended to use them for her.

"The lay," Voss said, turning the word over like a coin he wasn't sure was real currency anymore. "Wages owed a dead whaler off a ship that hasn't existed in a hundred-odd years. You understand there's no court in this county that opens that book again."

"I understand you're still holding the book," Ekon said. "That's the part I came about."

Voss gave it to him in the end — not out of conscience, Ekon was fairly sure, but because handing over a folder cost him nothing and refusing might eventually cost him something, and men like Voss ran their whole lives on that particular arithmetic. Ekon read it standing in the man's doorway rather than give him the satisfaction of watching a longer reaction: his ancestor's name, a ship's name, a sum, a lay percentage promised and never once paid, his mother's own hand in the margin where she'd once tried and failed to make the case to somebody who'd stopped listening before she finished the sentence.

It proved everything and changed nothing. The town would not open its books for a hundred-year debt regardless of what any lawyer's drawer produced, and he had known that walking in. He folded the document anyway, careful as a man folding a flag, and put it inside his coat, because some victories are worth having even when nobody official will ever agree to count them.

Voss was already turning back to his own desk when he stopped, opened a lower drawer with the particular reluctance of a man remembering an obligation he'd hoped had lapsed, and set a second folder on the blotter between them — thinner, older, water-stained along one edge.

"This isn't yours to claim, and I couldn't tell you how it ended up in with your mother's papers if you asked me twice," Voss said. He did not offer to try a third time. He pushed it an inch closer, the way a man pushes something he wants gone from his own conscience rather than something he means as a gift. "Take it if you want it. One less thing in my drawer."

Ekon did not know the name on the cover — *W. CORWIN, OFFICER, PRECINCT 4* — and had no reason to. He opened it anyway, standing in that same doorway, and read a stranger's cramped, deliberately legible hand recording six men in a rose garden and, beneath them in a hand pressed harder than the rest, two more the town's own history had never once agreed to count: a woman, a boy, and a single stubborn digit — *eight* — written where every official version he'd ever encountered of anything in this town insisted on six.

He stood there a long moment with the file in his hands, unable to say why it had struck him the way it had, only that he recognized something in a dead stranger's insistence on a number nobody official would ever honor, the way a man recognizes his own reflection in a window he wasn't looking for it in. He put it in his coat beside the wage claim, both folded the same careful way, and never once connected the officer's name to anything, because there was nothing yet in his life that could have told him to.

[MATCHES: 23]

The ruins on the drowned island were exactly the kind of ground the Army had trained him for and exactly the kind of ground nothing in his training had prepared him to want to enter twice. He went anyway, because the second dishonest document in his mother's file — the sanitized version, filed after some other man's death twenty years back, orderly and false and missing six murdered men and two more nobody official had ever bothered naming — told him plainly that somebody in this town had been burying inconvenient truths in shallow ground for a long time, and he had spent a war learning what he thought about men who did that from behind a desk instead of a rifle.

He moved through the collapsed sections with the flat, economical caution of a man who has already learned what happens to careless men in unstable structures, testing weight before trusting it, marking his own path back the way any competent soldier marks a route through unfamiliar terrain. When a support beam gave under him in the second gallery and dropped him eight feet onto broken masonry, he took the fall the way he'd been trained to take falls, rolled it out, came up with a cracked rib and nothing worse, and kept moving inside the hour because the Army had also taught him that stopping to feel sorry for an injury was a luxury a man in hostile ground rarely got to spend.

An old man met him at the mouth of the third gallery, standing where the light gave out — grayscale to the collar, a single ring on his hand catching color no lantern down here had any business giving it, and beside him, close enough to be working the same rope, a man perhaps forty who moved with the specific unhurried economy of someone who had learned his trade from exactly this teacher and no one else.

"You've come further than most who carry a rifle instead of a trowel," the old man said.

"I'm not digging," Ekon said. "I'm finishing something."

The old man considered that with an expression Ekon couldn't place — not quite approval, not quite warning. "There was another one, years back. Carried a trowel instead of a rifle. Went further than we go, same as you're about to. He never came back up either." He nodded once, not unkindly. "We don't tell you not to go. We only ever tell you what it costs. What a man does with the price is his own business, same as it was his."

The younger man beside him said nothing at all, only watched Ekon's hands the way a man watches another man's hands when he is deciding, privately, whether they belong to someone competent. Ekon understood, without being told, that he had just been measured by the same standard the old man had once used on the boy now standing beside him, and had — he could not have said how he knew, only that he knew — been found adequate.

He met exactly one hazard in those first galleries that a rifle solved cleanly — something that had once been a man and no longer troubled itself with the distinction, coming at him out of a side passage with the loose, wet-jointed hurry of a thing that had forgotten what its own body

was for. He put three rounds into it with the flat unhesitating competence of a man who had done this before, for reasons, in places he didn't write home about, and it went down and stayed down, and he felt — for one clean, uncomplicated moment — like a man finally facing a problem his training had actual jurisdiction over.

[MATCHES: 21]

He was, for a little while, allowed to believe that.

Deeper in, past a threshold his own map called the end of any reasonable itinerary, he came on a second one of the same general shape, and shot it the same clean way, three rounds, center mass, the same total confidence — and watched it stagger, fold at the middle the way a man folds when the wind's been knocked from him, and keep coming regardless. He put two more into it before he understood what he was looking at: not a wounded man refusing to acknowledge a wound, but something for which the wound simply wasn't the kind of information that mattered. He gave it ground rather than press the issue, the way a soldier gives ground to weather rather than argue with it, and it did not pursue him past the gallery's threshold, content, apparently, to have made its point.

He understood, retreating, that the first thing he'd killed and the second thing he'd only staggered had looked, to an untrained eye, like the same category of trouble, and were not. He had no stat, no meter, nothing a man could point to and call a warning system. He had only his own two eyes and the plain fact of what had and hadn't gone down permanently, filed the way any competent soldier files the difference between an enemy who can be killed and one who can only be delayed, because the difference, once learned, tends to keep a man alive considerably longer than the man who never bothers learning it.

[MATCHES: 18]

He passed, in a side gallery he had no professional reason to enter and entered anyway, a scatter of small objects laid out with obvious care on a shelf of dry stone — a scrimshawed comb, a corroded ship's bell, a handful of lesser things arranged the way a man arranges an inheritance he intends to come back for. He recognized, without knowing why, that whoever had left them here had meant to return, and had not.

He did not take any of it. He turned the comb over once in his hand, felt its weight, its age, the specific patience of the work in it, and set it back exactly where he'd found it. He was not here to carry anything out that wasn't his to carry, and the weight of it — one more thing to account for, one more slot spent on a stranger's unfinished collection — struck him as exactly the kind of

distraction a man in his position could not afford. He had a rifle, a wage claim, a dead officer's forgotten file, and a fuse he had not yet needed. That was the whole of what he'd come to carry, and he meant to leave with precisely that and nothing more.

He found the book in a chamber two galleries past where his own survey map insisted nothing further should exist, resting where a man had apparently sat down deliberately to read it rather than dropped it in flight. Beside it: a corroded field notebook, swollen shut with damp, and the long-settled shape of what had once, a decade or so back by the state of it, been a man about his own age.

He sat with the stranger a while before he touched anything, the way he'd learned to sit with the dead overseas before you went through their effects — not reverence exactly, something more like a debt you paid a man for having been a person before he became a body. The notebook, once he worked it open, was a stranger's obsessive, meticulous catalog of a season's finds, entries running clean and rigorous for a hundred pages and then, toward the end, running into numbers that skipped and doubled back on themselves, descriptions of objects the man could not possibly have found yet. Ekon had no way of knowing the name Ward Kohistani, would never know it, and understood anyway, reading that ledger start to finish in the bad light of a match he was rationing, that whoever this had been had died doing careful, honest work, and that nobody besides Ekon would ever tell him so.

"You did the job," he said aloud, to a dead stranger who couldn't hear him, and meant it the way he meant very few things he said in that season.

[MATCHES: 15]

The book beside the ledger held two hands of marginal notes he didn't yet know belonged to two different men in two different decades, one flattering a delusion, one chasing an honest question, neither aware the other's hand had ever touched the same page. Ekon read the passage they'd both underlined — a plain scholarly account of a minor figure from old Greek cosmogony, a serpent-god half-remembered and mostly discredited even by people who studied that sort of thing for a living — and felt something in the base of his skull go very cold, because he had heard that name before, more than once, carved into stonework in a private club on the mainland whose members' six-decades-dead scandal his mother's file had never fully explained, and in a business name over on the Ophion Trust building where, he now understood without anyone telling him, a rich man's family had named their fortune after the very thing that had made it.

He thought, briefly and without being able to say why, of a dead officer's stubborn eight written into a margin nobody official had ever agreed to read. He did not connect the two files consciously — there was nothing in either that named the other — but some part of him filed

them beside each other anyway, the way a man files two facts that feel, without evidence, like they belong to the same drawer.

Nobody in the game he was playing was going to say it out loud for him. He understood it anyway, in the same silent, arriving way you understand a formation is about to be overrun a half-second before the order comes down.

The gallery beyond the drowned man's chamber opened onto a stretch of cavern that stopped behaving like a cavern should. He advanced on it exactly the way three years of training told him to advance on unclear ground — line of sight, cover, controlled pace — right up until the moment the training simply ran out of relevant instructions, because nothing in a soldier's manual covers what to do when the walls themselves seem to be listening for your footsteps and you cannot say what would happen if they liked what they heard.

There was a stretch of narrow passage a patient man could take without ever announcing himself, and he took it the patient way, closing the distance on his own terms rather than the ground's — the one advantage his training had ever actually handed him down here, choosing when a fight started rather than only how it ended. It bought him a clean approach on the last of the man-shaped things between him and the abyss's mouth, and he put it down without ceremony, three rounds, the same flat competence as before, and told himself, for the length of exactly one breath, that he had this handled.

[MATCHES: 11]

Then the passage ended in a drop no rope he carried was long enough for, into a dark his lantern could not find the bottom of, and something down there that had never once needed to be a man-shaped thing to be a threat looked back up at him — not hunting, not hostile, simply present, the way a mountain is present to a man standing on its slope — and every ounce of trained competence he had walked in with sat in his hands and did precisely nothing, because there was nothing down there built the way a rifle understands things being built. He had spent three years and one war becoming a man capable of solving almost anything put in front of him with force applied correctly, and he understood, standing at that drop with his weapon useless in his own two hands, that this was the first problem he had met in his adult life that did not have a jurisdiction for that answer at all.

His training did not abandon him. It simply changed subject, the way a soldier's training always eventually does when the objective stops being the enemy and starts being everyone behind him he still has a chance to get out alive. He couldn't kill what was down there. He could deny it ground. He found the charges he'd carried in for exactly this kind of collapse-and-seal contingency, set them along the passage's weakest span, and understood with total clarity that

he was not fighting anymore so much as retreating with intent — burning the ground behind him so that whatever was down there inherited nothing but rubble for its trouble.

[MATCHES: 4]

He went down anyway, before he lit the fuse, because some part of him — the same part that had walked into Voss's office already knowing the town would never pay, the same part that had sat with a stranger's remains and said *you did the job* to a man who couldn't hear it — needed to look the thing in whatever passed for its face before he did the one thing left to do about it.

What he found down there did not resolve into an answer his eyes were built to hold. It was not the mother-shape that had unmade Walter Corwin, wasn't wearing any face borrowed from Ekon's own life the way it had worn one from his — perhaps because Ekon had no unresolved dead mother's voice sitting close enough to the surface for it to reach for, or perhaps only because it had already spent its favorite trick twenty years back and had no further use for repeating itself on a man who would not have found comfort in a familiar face anyway. It simply was, entire and unbroken and entirely without interest in whether Ekon understood any part of it, and understanding — the same understanding that had cost Walter his life and cost Ward his — arrived in Ekon whole and immediate and did not kill him outright, only because there was, by then, almost nothing left of the passage between them for it to travel through before the charges did their work.

[MATCHES: 1]

He had one clear-headed moment left, the only such moment either of his predecessors had ever been granted and neither had lived lucid enough to use. He had, in his coat, four things now rather than the two he'd walked in with: the wage claim, proven and uncollectable; a dead stranger's honest, complete ledger; a dead officer's file with its stubborn, uncounted eight; and the fuse in his other hand. He understood, in that last clear second, that he could not carry everything back up into daylight ahead of him, that something here would have to be sealed against the wet and the dark along with whatever this passage was about to become, and that the choosing itself — not the outcome, which nothing he did now would change — was the one thing left entirely his to decide.

He thought of his mother, who had gone looking for one true document in a town built to lose them, and of a dead cop's stubborn insistence on a number nobody was ever going to honor, and of a dead stranger's decade of honest, uncelebrated work, and understood that a man could not save all three, only choose which ones went home with a chance of being believed and which ones stayed here with him, sealed the same careful way he'd once folded a hundred-year-old debt into his coat outside a lawyer's office — a decision nobody else in this family had ever been given the composure left to make for himself.

He lit the fuse.

[MATCHES: 0]

The film stock does not fail so much as it refuses. It does not flicker or glitch the way a lesser medium might, pretending at malfunction to spare itself the honesty of admitting what it's actually looking at. It burns, curls, and dissolves along its own edges, the emulsion giving up frame by frame the way paper gives up to flame, because whatever the lens has been asked to hold is larger than the stock's willingness to keep holding it.

The camera does not linger to watch the rest. It pulls back — through collapsing rock, through packed earth that should stop a lens as surely as it stops a man, up and away and out — and settles, at the very last, on the Ophion estate's manicured lawn above, green and tended and entirely, permanently unaware that anything at all had ever happened beneath it.

Somewhere on the ground above, where he'd sent it ahead of him sealed against the wet and the dark, a folded document waits for nobody, proving a claim a hundred years dead — carried out rather than left behind in a careless lawyer's drawer. Somewhere else — nobody will ever say exactly where, because nobody living was left to say it — a ledger and a stubborn, uncounted number either survived the fire or didn't, sealed or burned by a choice made in the dark by the only man in three generations of this family given the clarity left to make one on purpose.

The debt went on unpaid, the way it always had been, exactly as indifferent to being finally noticed as it had ever been to being owed.

END OF CHAPTER THREE